

Untitled Fish Detective Game

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Game Identity

- An educational detective game where you play as a fish detective.
- Fixed levels, gathering clues, discovering books that tell you real-life facts about how marine predators catch their prey, all while working with the "Fish Police" to interrogate suspects and solve cases at the end of each level, which plays into a story.

Key Pillars

- Puzzles
- Educational
- Absurdist
- Mystery

Themes and Genre

- Educational murder-mystery adventure
- Noir aesthetic
- Puzzle-solving exploration

Visual Style

- Some form of Noir pixel art, with most of the levels set at night to evoke the feel of traditional murder-mystery media.
- Include dithering to further emphasise the Noir aesthetic and to make the player assume this is a dark and gritty world.
- This visual style would contrast with the comedic attitude of the characters and would make the player assume that this is an extremely serious game upon first impression.
- Although this is a "Fish Detective" game, its absurdity derives from the idea that everything that takes place in the game happens on land instead of sea. These characters are anthropomorphised. Every character in the game wears 1930s-style clothes; they use old-timey slang, and they walk around on two legs but still retain the appearance of their species of fish.
- Inside areas take place in bars, speakeasies, opera theatres, and many more period-specific locations.

- Outside areas take place in the docks, the beach, and parks.
- The concept for the visual style of the game was largely inspired by Undertale. It is an example of minimalist but stylised pixel art that this game could take inspiration from whilst also including a more focused theme with the period-specific Noir aesthetic.



Music and Sound

- As there will be multiple areas to each fixed level, there will be different types of music for each area; however, there will be a specific pattern that is followed.
- Outside areas - Ambience of waves crashing, birds chirping, boats slightly colliding with each other on the pier.
- Inside areas - Dark ambient music, classical jazz, orchestral scores.
- This choice of audio is designed to make the player feel immersed in the environments typical of the Noir genre.

Narrative

- 1920s-1930s time period similar to the Great Depression
- 'Fishtopia' is the city that this is taking place in.
- Follows a fish detective introduced to the player at the start of the game through a cutscene that shows this detective accusing a clownfish suspect of murder.
- This clownfish suspect runs away, and you must gather clues as to where the suspect went. Most people will realise that clownfish do not hunt or attack prey; however, they can aggressively defend their territory. This is not the true antagonist of the story..
- After the first level, the clownfish admits they didn't kill the victim of the murder, but they work for someone who might have some idea.
- This leads to a consecutive number of levels the player must solve and find the right suspects for by using information gathered around the crime scene and the actual bodies of the victims themselves.
- Side characters will include fish police, regular fishtizens, accomplices to murder, and other power-hungry crime bosses that the detective regularly communicates

with to help get the job done in return for turning a blind eye to their crimes. Typical of Noir detective narratives, a moral grayness emerges. The fish detective is thrust into situations in which ethical lines become blurred.

- Unsure of an ending, but this string of murders likely points to a certain trumpetfish serial killer (they hunt other fish by harmlessly swimming alongside them before taking their chance to strike).

Game Loop

- As the fish detective, you will explore fixed levels, finding books that tell you about different species of fish and their stats.
- Collecting these books will save them to your 'Journal Notes', which will give a summary of the species you have read about.
- Exploring a crime scene, you will find many different clues scattered around the area; you will also be able to inspect the body of the victim, which will tell you how they were killed.
- After talking to an officer specifically made to help the player out, this officer can take you to the suspect room, where you will have a chance to ask each suspect a question whilst also being able to check your 'Journal Notes' to identify which species of suspect may have committed the murder.

Target Market

- This game is mainly aimed at teens and adults who enjoy traditional Murder-Mysteries but are also looking for some sense of absurdity.
- I firmly believe there is an open market niche for Murder-Mystery/Puzzle-solving games that hold an outlandish comedic feel. Too many games lean into one side or the other; maybe the game is too depressing or brutish, or it's too silly and comedic. I think that players desire a mix of gloomy or murky aesthetics paired with humorous dialogue and narrative.

Platform

- This would be planned to release on Steam.